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Karnataka has improved transport affordability through subsidies and schemes, yet reliable access remains uneven in rural areas. Using insights from Melukote, this article examines

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whether schools, workplaces, or markets. The [Karnataka Economic Survey 2023–24](#) notes that gaps in road connectivity and public transport services remain a persistent barrier to rural development. Despite multi-year investments in the transport sector aimed at reducing transportation costs, including initiatives such as the Shakti Scheme and subsidised student bus passes, accessibility in terms of service adequacy and network coverage remains uneven in rural Karnataka.

The situation in Melukote, in Mandya district of Karnataka, illustrates this broader structural issue in Karnataka. Limited bus services, few routes, and weak last-mile connectivity have restricted mobility, reflecting that transport supply and regulatory frameworks have not kept pace with growing demand.

In Melukote, the Shakti Scheme has increased women’s patronage of the state buses, with field findings mirroring [state-wide study](#) findings that show travel among beneficiaries has increased by up to 65%. Similarly, there is a broader dependence on public transport among rural students, with a survey at Government Degree College, Pandavapura, showing that 90 per cent of students rely on KSRTC buses. While these schemes have made mobility more affordable, they have also intensified pressure on the sole public transport system provided by the Karnataka State Road Transport Corporation (KSRTC).

Affordability ≠ Access

The dependence on public transport would be less problematic if services were frequent and flexible. However, public transport availability in the Melukote region is limited in scale and frequency, leading to peak-hour overcrowding. Many villages lack direct bus service, requiring residents to walk several kilometres to reach the nearest stop.

Limited access forces residents to organise their daily travel around bus timings. For instance, teachers at degree and pre-university colleges reveal that they routinely cut instructional hours short so students can catch the 3:30 PM bus, the last reliable service of the day, which takes students home when there is still daylight. Requests from



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In principle, gaps in public transport provision could be offset by private or shared mobility services. In practice, such alternatives have failed to emerge at scale due to the rigid distinction between contract carriage (for hire) and stage carriages (public bus) operation in Indian and State laws.

The Melukote region previously had privately operated passenger bus lines operating along several routes. According to the Mandya Regional Transport Officer, many of these operations ceased during the pandemic due to difficulties paying taxes and maintaining vehicles, and the subsequent introduction of the Shakthi Scheme, which diverted a section of fare-paying commuters towards state buses.

Autorickshaws and taxis are commonly available at major bus stations and town centres and often operate as shared vehicles to reduce per-passenger costs. The regulatory provisions for contract carriages under the Motor Vehicles Act, 1988, as currently interpreted, does not formally permit such shared operations, forcing operators either to charge higher per-trip fares or to operate informally with fear of enforcement. In the absence of a supportive legal framework, private and shared transport services are unable to complement public transport, leaving rural travellers dependent on a single overstretched provider.

Recommendations

Affordability-driven mobility without adequate supply fails to ensure meaningful access to rural residents. States like Karnataka must reimagine how they plan and regulate rural transport to address the issue of limited accessibility.

Beyond introducing a few new bus services that again get shut down due to low occupancy, the state must create space for smaller shared-vehicle operators to complement public transport by removing barriers to the operations of these vehicles. The shared autorickshaw and mini-bus models in neighbouring Tamil Nadu, which are regulated differently from stage carriages, offer a useful reference point. The flexibility provided by the Motor Vehicles (Amendment) Act 2019 allows states to take up creative initiatives like this to improve rural mobility and last mile

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Views expressed by the authors are personal and need not reflect or represent the views of the Centre for Public Policy Research (CPPR).

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